

2026 Local Ballot Research Guide

Greenville County and Travelers Rest

Prepared for the Travelers Rest 1 sample ballot

This guide explains the three local questions on the attached sample ballot, traces the legal and financial mechanics, summarizes the strongest evidence for and against each proposal, and identifies what remains uncertain. It is designed to help you make your own informed decision; it does not tell you how to vote.

Ballot scope

The user-provided PDF is a sample ballot and says, on page 1, that it is not the ballot used to cast a vote. The local questions are on page 5. I treated the ballot text as source material, not as instructions to the researcher.

Question	What it asks	Headline amount
1. County tax	A countywide 1% sales/use tax for transportation, transit, and greenbelts	\$1.1 billion maximum
2. County bonds	Up to \$150 million in general obligation bonds tied to Question 1	\$150 million principal
3. Travelers Rest tax	A city 1% sales/use tax with project funding and homeowner credits	\$15.826 million listed projects

Election context: the county ordinance schedules the referendum for November 3, 2026. The county questions are separate votes. Travelers Rest Question 3 is also separate, although the taxes could stack on the same taxable purchase inside the city.

Research date: September 20, 2026

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The short version

The most important distinctions are the tax base, the spending flexibility, and the fact that the bond question is not the same thing as the tax question.

Question	If YES	Main tradeoff / uncertainty
1. County 1% tax	Creates a countywide tax for up to 8 years or until \$1.1 billion is collected. The ordinance allocates up to \$990M roads, \$33M transit, and \$77M greenbelts.	Broad categories rather than a fixed project list; sales-tax burden is generally more regressive; grocery treatment under the final county text needs confirmation.
2. County bonds	Authorizes up to \$150M of initial borrowing, payable from the Question 1 tax, so projects can be delivered earlier.	Debt service uses part of the Question 1 ceiling. The 2026 ballot text does not spell out a county property-tax fallback; obtain the bond documents if that matters to you.
3. Travelers Rest 1% tax	Funds listed city projects and dedicates at least 20% of city-tax revenue to credits against municipal property tax for qualifying owner-occupied homes.	The credit is not a 20% reduction of every homeowner's bill. It excludes renters and non-owner-occupied property, while project estimates and category numbers have moved slightly across city documents.

A practical way to think about the ballot

Question 1 decides whether to create the county revenue stream. Question 2 decides whether to borrow against that stream up front. Question 3 is a separate city tax that trades some sales-tax revenue for both city capital projects and a municipal property-tax credit.

What the ballot does not do

- It does not give the county a published, voter-approved list of individual road projects. The final county ordinance uses broad project purposes and annual budgeting.
- It does not make Travelers Rest's credit a credit against county or school-district taxes. The statute describes a credit against qualifying municipal ad valorem liability.
- It does not make a Question 1 YES automatically mean Question 2 YES. The votes are separate, and the ballot presents them separately.
- It does not settle every implementation detail today. County and city ordinances, later budgets, DOR administration, engineering, grants, bids, and bond documents still matter.

QUESTION 1

Greenville County special sales/use tax

This is the county's main funding question: one additional percentage point on applicable taxable sales and uses for a limited term and limited purposes.

Ballot mechanics

The final county ordinance authorizes a 1% tax for no more than eight years, or until \$1.1 billion has been collected, whichever comes first. If approved and certified, the tax is scheduled to begin May 1, 2027. The overall cap includes administration and debt service. The tax is in addition to other applicable state and local sales/use taxes.

The allocation written into the ballot

Purpose	Maximum	Share of \$1.1B	What the ordinance permits
Highways, roads, streets, bridges, transportation facilities, related drainage	\$990,000,000	90%	Road, bridge, drainage, and other transportation-related projects and facilities.
Mass transit	\$33,000,000	3%	Systems operated by Greenville County or jointly with other governmental entities, including operation or expansion consistent with the Greenlink Transit Development Plan.
Greenbelts	\$77,000,000	7%	Land or conservation easements for parks, green space, sports fields, water access, trails, wildlife, floodwater management, farms/forests, natural resources, historic preservation, and water quality.

The three maximums add to \$1.1 billion. Because debt service and administration are also within the overall ceiling, the amount available for direct project work may be less than the simple sum suggests.

How flexible is the spending?

- The 2026 measure is materially broader than the failed 2024 referendum. The 2026 ballot does not name a fixed list of individual roads or facilities; the county ordinance establishes purposes, caps, annual budgeting, and oversight.
- County Council adopts annual budgets. Outside agencies can request funds. The ordinance allows transfers among approved projects or purposes with Council approval, subject to the referendum's categories and restrictions.
- Municipalities that have not imposed the separate Municipal Tax Relief Act tax can receive a pro-rata share of taxable sales within the municipality, after the ordinance's 20% reduction and prorating rules. This is not a promise that every municipality receives the same project list.

Tax treatment: an important unresolved detail

South Carolina law exempts certain maximum-tax items, SNAP-purchased food, and other categories; the local statute also permits a county to elect an exemption for unprepared food in later referenda. The final Greenville County ordinance I reviewed expressly addresses maximum-tax items and USDA Food Stamps, but I did not find a blanket statement exempting all unprepared groceries. Therefore, do not assume that every ordinary grocery purchase will be exempt from Question 1 until the county or SCDOR publishes definitive administration guidance. This is one of the most important items to verify before voting.

What \$1 means

On a \$100 taxable purchase, a 1% county tax adds about \$1. On a \$1,000 taxable purchase, it adds about \$10. That arithmetic applies only to transactions in the tax base; it is not an estimate of any one household's annual cost.

QUESTION 1

Why supporters say the county needs it

The strongest case for Question 1 is a documented infrastructure gap combined with restricted existing revenue.

Road and bridge need evidence

Evidence	What county materials said	How to interpret it
Network size	About 4,000 lane miles; approximately 1,800 county roads and 1,600 state roads were cited in a 2024 County Council staff presentation.	The county does not control every road in the network. A county tax can fund county projects and potentially joint or eligible projects, but it cannot erase state or municipal responsibilities.
Condition	About 75% of arterial and collector roads were described as fair or poor; about 15% of bridges were described as load-restricted or closed.	These are staff-reported planning figures from 2024, not a new independent engineering audit. They are still useful evidence of scale.
Safety	The same presentation cited 399 road deaths from 2017 through 2021.	Safety is a real potential benefit, but the ballot does not identify which specific safety treatments will be built first.
Funding gap	FY2023 roads investment was about \$94.2M, but only about \$12M was described as unrestricted county local funding; the rest was largely state or federal money with restrictions.	A sales tax can provide flexible local match and construction money, but it also creates a new broad-based charge.
Scale estimate	County staff used a rough 'magic checkbook' estimate of about \$2B to address fair/poor roads, with about \$1B for state/county/GPATS/high-priority needs.	This is a rough order-of-magnitude estimate, not a promise that the \$990M road category fixes every road.

The FY2026 county budget separately shows about \$36.2M for the county road program, including paving, sidewalks, bridge replacement, road improvements, and traffic calming. That figure is not directly comparable to the referendum's \$990M gross category: the budget is one fiscal-year program with different funding sources and restrictions, while the referendum would run for up to eight years and could include debt service.

Transit and greenbelts

- The transit allocation is capped at \$33M, or an average of \$4.125M per year if spread evenly across eight years. Greenlink's FY2025 operating expenses were about \$13.8M, so that annualized figure is meaningful in scale, but capital and operating dollars are not interchangeable and the ordinance does not promise a specific service schedule.
- The greenbelt category is intentionally broad. It can support land, easements, trails, parks, water access, natural-resource protection, floodwater management, farms/forests, historic preservation, and water quality. The final county measure does not give voters a parcel-by-parcel map.

Oversight and accountability

- The tax must be kept in a separate fund. DOR administers the tax, with administration capped at 1% of the revenue collected.
- County Council must budget the money annually. The ordinance provides for independent annual audits.
- A transparency committee of at least six members is appointed by County Council. It must meet publicly at least quarterly and review appropriations and expenditures, but it does not select projects.
- The committee is not a substitute for a fixed project list. Its strength is public review after the elected Council makes spending decisions.

QUESTION 1

Costs, existing fees, and the strongest objections

A fair analysis has to ask not only whether the projects are needed, but also who pays, how much discretion exists, and what happens to existing charges.

The existing \$25 road-maintenance fee

Greenville County currently charges a \$25 annual road-maintenance fee per vehicle. County code dedicates it to a special road account, including road maintenance, improvements, and debt service. A September 15, 2026 County Council resolution expresses the Council's intent to repeal the fee if the sales tax passes, but it is an intent resolution, not a completed repeal. The fee is also tied to Woodruff Road bypass bond debt. Do not count on immediate fee savings unless a final repeal and a legally workable debt plan are enacted.

Benefits supporters would point to

- A dedicated, limited-term revenue source could make a large backlog addressable instead of relying on year-to-year discretionary funding.
- A local match can help attract or unlock state and federal transportation money.
- Road and bridge improvements can affect safety, travel time, freight, economic development, and stormwater resilience.
- Transit and greenbelts are included in the same funding package, rather than leaving all transportation spending to roads alone.

Main objections and risks

- Sales taxes are generally regressive: lower-income households tend to spend a larger share of their income on taxable consumption. The local tax may be worthwhile to a voter while still placing a proportionally heavier burden on households with less disposable income.
- The county measure's broad categories provide flexibility, but they make it harder for voters to verify a specific promise before the election.
- The tax could last eight years and the cap includes debt service. If borrowing is used, the county commits future tax revenue before all projects are built.
- The county tax does not provide a direct homeowner credit. Any benefit to a property owner is indirect unless a particular project improves that property or neighborhood.
- The grocery treatment is not clear enough in the final county ordinance to treat it as settled. That uncertainty matters most to households that spend a large share of their budget on food.

A useful decision test

If you support the needs but dislike open-ended project selection, focus on whether the ordinance's caps, annual budgets, audits, and transparency committee are enough accountability for you. If you support the projects but oppose the tax base, ask whether there is a credible replacement revenue source; the ballot itself does not provide one.

QUESTION 2

The county general-obligation bond question

Question 2 is a financing question attached to Question 1. It is separately voted on and should be evaluated separately.

What a YES authorizes

Up to \$150 million of general obligation bonds, with maturities of no more than eight years, to complete projects in the categories described in Question 1. The ballot says the bonds are payable from the special sales/use tax in Question 1.

Why issue bonds?

- Borrowing can front-load construction. Roads, bridges, land, and right-of-way can cost more if the county waits several years for pay-as-you-go collections.
- Up-front money can help the county coordinate large projects and compete for grants or other funds that require a local match.
- Bond proceeds can make the first years of the tax more visible to voters, because projects may start before the full eight years of tax collections occur.

What the bond changes

Feature	Question 1 without the bond authorization	Question 1 plus Question 2
Timing	More pay-as-you-go; project timing follows collections, grants, and annual budgets.	Up to \$150M can be borrowed early, with repayment from the special tax.
Total tax ceiling	The \$1.1B ceiling still governs the special tax.	Bond principal and debt service are within the tax-funded financing plan; borrowing is not free extra money.
Interest	Less or no bond interest on the initial work, depending on later financing.	Interest and issuance costs consume some of the tax revenue that could otherwise pay for direct projects.
Risk	Construction may be slower or more exposed to inflation and funding delays.	The county commits future tax receipts and has less flexibility if collections disappoint or priorities change.

Important legal question to ask

The final 2026 ballot text I reviewed says the bonds are payable from the special tax and does not state a county property-tax fallback. That is different from simply proving that no legal backstop could ever exist for a general-obligation bond. If the possibility of a property-tax pledge would change your vote, ask for the proposed bond ordinance, bond counsel opinion, and repayment documents before relying on a campaign summary.

Voting combinations

- Question 1 YES / Question 2 YES: approve the tax and authorize initial borrowing against it.
- Question 1 YES / Question 2 NO: approve the tax but do not give this ballot authorization for the \$150M bond program. Projects would rely on pay-as-you-go collections, grants, or later action.
- Question 1 NO / Question 2 YES: this is not a coherent funding package on the face of the ballot, because Question 2 says the bonds are payable from the Question 1 tax. Seek an official explanation rather than assuming the bonds could proceed unchanged.
- Question 1 NO / Question 2 NO: reject the county tax-and-bond package.

QUESTION 3

Travelers Rest municipal tax relief and projects

This is a separate city referendum created under South Carolina's Municipal Tax Relief Act. It combines capital projects with a credit against qualifying municipal property-tax liability.

Ballot numbers

The sample ballot lists a 1% city sales/use tax for up to eight years, with \$15,826,000 in project categories: \$3,942,000 connectors/trails/sidewalks; \$2,613,500 public parking; \$4,958,500 public assembly; \$3,062,000 critical roadway repairs; and \$1,250,000 drainage infrastructure.

How the homeowner credit works

- State law requires at least 20% of the municipal sales-tax revenue to be used for credits against municipal ad valorem tax liability for qualifying owner-occupied residential property.
- That is a share of tax revenue dedicated to credits; it is not a promise that every homeowner's tax bill falls by 20%.
- The city estimates approximately \$3.9M in homeowner credits over eight years, with approximately \$15.8M for capital projects. Its projection shows collections ramping from about \$2.19M in the first year to about \$2.79M in the eighth year, or about \$19.7M over eight years in total.
- The credit is for owner-occupied residential property within the city. Renters, second homes, and non-owner-occupied property do not receive this owner-occupied credit. The credit is against municipal liability, not a general reduction of county or school taxes.
- The city's public estimate uses the formula taxable home value x 0.0011120. The examples below are estimates, not guarantees; taxable value, collections, the number of qualifying properties, and future city tax liability can change.

Illustrative taxable home value	Estimated annual credit
\$150,000	\$166.80
\$250,000	\$278.01
\$400,000	\$444.81
\$500,000	\$556.01

For eligible owners, unused credit can roll forward under the statute for up to three years. That helps if a credit exceeds current municipal liability, but it does not convert the credit into cash or into a credit against unrelated taxes.

What is likely taxed and exempt

Travelers Rest says the city tax would generally apply to prepared food, retail, home goods, and discretionary purchases. The city says gasoline, rent and mortgages, utilities, most groceries, and prescriptions are not taxed. The state statute separately exempts unprepared food and SNAP-purchased food for this municipal tax. The city also has an existing 2% local hospitality tax on prepared meals and beverages; that is a separate tax and can matter when comparing the cost of a restaurant purchase.

QUESTION 3

The Travelers Rest project list

The city describes 29 projects in two tiers. Tier 1 is intended to proceed first; Tier 2 can begin after a threshold is met and subject to later Council decisions.

Ballot category breakdown

Category on ballot	Amount	Approx. share of listed projects
Connectors / trails / sidewalks	\$3,942,000	24.9%
Public parking infrastructure	\$2,613,500	16.5%
Public assembly infrastructure	\$4,958,500	31.3%
Critical roadway repairs	\$3,062,000	19.4%
Drainage infrastructure	\$1,250,000	7.9%
Total	\$15,826,000	100%

Tier 1 projects - city packet estimate

Project	Estimated cost
Trailblazer Regional Pond	\$1,250,000.00
Old Buncombe Road renovation	\$2,240,000.00
Gateway Park / Center Street access	\$111,436.65
Gateway internal drive and parallel parking	\$460,530.00
Gateway splash pad	\$1,386,750.00
Gateway pickleball	\$431,569.50
Center Street SRT connection	\$390,000.00
Gateway sidewalk loop	\$223,634.40
Trailblazer connector	\$412,574.00
115 Henderson parking	\$428,473.50
Little Texas roundabout	\$250,000.00
Tier 1 total	\$7,584,968.05

Tier 2 projects - city packet estimate

Project	Estimated cost
Gateway skate park	\$700,000.00
Gateway stadium seating	\$425,184.00
Gateway feature playground	\$2,013,045.00
315 Trailblazer parking	\$1,257,517.80
126 N. Poinsett parking	\$148,342.00
6711 State Park parking	\$216,000.00
700 Old Buncombe parking	\$426,306.30
11 Center Street parking	\$136,804.50
Williams SRT	\$796,000.00
Williams-to-Tubbs sidewalk	\$226,000.00
North Main: high school to The Refuge	\$495,000.00
North Main: The Refuge to Scruggs	\$272,000.00
Foothills SRT	\$182,600.00
Watson SRT	\$31,400.00
McElhaney SRT	\$94,400.00
Saddleback SRT	\$334,000.00
Main Street to Old City Hall	\$263,000.00
South End Circle	\$221,400.00
Tier 2 total	\$8,238,999.60

QUESTION 3

Implementation, revisions, and tradeoffs

The city has published more project detail than the county, but the published estimates are still planning estimates rather than guaranteed bids.

How the city says implementation would work

- The tax would run from May 1, 2027 through April 30, 2035, unless it ends earlier under the statute.
- The city ordinance creates a separate account and requires an annual report within 90 days after the fiscal year. The city says the reports will show collections, credits, and project spending.
- Tier 1 comes first. After at least 70% of current-tier contracts are let, the Council can begin the next tier. The Council can reorder lower-tier work when delays, right-of-way, permits, grants, bid overruns, or unforeseen conditions affect delivery.
- The city ordinance does not authorize bonded indebtedness for this tax. That makes the city plan primarily pay-as-you-go, unlike the county's separate bond question.
- The city's project map says approved projects will not be changed, but site plans and visual representations can evolve. Scope, design, and cost control therefore remain important oversight questions.

A small but meaningful document discrepancy

Document	What it shows	Why it matters
Sample ballot / current city tax-relief page	Final ballot category figures totaling \$15,826,000, including \$3,942,000 connectors/trails/sidewalks and \$2,613,500 parking.	These are the figures printed for the vote and should be treated as the controlling category caps.
July 2026 Council packet	Earlier rounded category figures: \$3,943,000; \$2,614,000; \$4,957,000; \$3,062,000; \$1,250,000.	Shows that category estimates moved before the ballot version.
August 10, 2026 Council packet Exhibit A	Project estimate total of \$15,823,967.65; Tier 1 \$7,584,968.05; Tier 2 \$8,238,999.60. The splash-pad estimate is revised to \$1,386,750.	The project list is slightly below the ballot category total and is an estimate. A final signed ordinance/Exhibit A should reconcile the figures.

How to use the discrepancy

It is small relative to the whole program, but it is a useful accountability signal: use the ballot category amounts when evaluating the vote, and ask the city for the signed ordinance and final exhibit before treating any individual project estimate as fixed.

Benefits supporters would point to

- The package gives Travelers Rest a visible list of sidewalks, trails, parking, civic/recreation facilities, roadway work, and drainage projects.
- Eligible owner-occupants receive a direct municipal property-tax credit, which can partially offset the city sales tax for those households.
- A separate fund, annual reporting, a 70% tier threshold, and no current bond authorization make the structure more constrained than the county package.

Main objections and risks

- A resident who rents, owns a second home, or owns non-owner-occupied property pays the sales tax but does not receive the owner-occupied municipal credit.
- The credit is tied to municipal tax liability and taxable value; it is not cash and does not offset county or school taxes.
- The largest ballot category is public assembly infrastructure. Voters who prefer roads or drainage may view the package as too recreation-heavy, while others may see the civic/recreation investment as the point.

- Project estimates can change with bids, inflation, permits, land acquisition, and design. The tier rules leave the Council some discretion over sequencing.
- The city tax can stack with the county tax on the same taxable city purchase if both pass.

CROSS-QUESTION ANALYSIS

What happens if both sales taxes pass?

The two taxes are legally separate, but a shopper inside Travelers Rest could encounter both on the same taxable transaction.

Scenario	Additional amount on a \$100 taxable purchase	Additional amount on a \$1,000 taxable purchase
County Question 1 only	About \$1	About \$10
Travelers Rest Question 3 only	About \$1	About \$10
Both pass and both apply	About \$2	About \$20

These amounts are incremental taxes before whatever state, existing local, or hospitality taxes already apply. They are not an annual household bill. The true burden depends on where you shop, what you buy, whether a category is exempt, and how much of your spending is taxable.

Questions to ask yourself

- Do the county's road, bridge, transit, and greenbelt needs justify a broad sales/use tax for up to eight years?
- Is the county's broad-category and annual-budget structure enough accountability without a fixed project list?
- Would you support county projects but prefer pay-as-you-go financing, making Question 1 YES / Question 2 NO the better fit?
- If you live in Travelers Rest, are you an owner-occupant likely to receive the municipal credit, or would you mostly pay the tax without that offset?
- Do the Travelers Rest project categories match your priorities, especially the public assembly and recreation share?
- How much weight do you place on sales-tax regressivity, grocery uncertainty, and the existing road-maintenance fee?
- Would the possibility of future property-tax exposure from county bond mechanics change your Question 2 vote?

A balanced reading of the choices

A YES vote can be understood as accepting a defined, time-limited tax in exchange for infrastructure, transit, land conservation, or city amenities. A NO vote can be understood as rejecting the tax structure, the project priorities, the financing risk, the accountability design, or some combination of those. There is no single 'objective' answer because the ballot asks voters to weigh distributional costs against public investments that may be difficult to fund from existing revenue.

Before voting, verify these three items

(1) SCDOR's final guidance on ordinary unprepared groceries under the county tax; (2) the county's proposed bond documents and any legal backstop for Question 2; and (3) Travelers Rest's final signed ordinance and Exhibit A reconciling the \$15.826M ballot categories with the current project estimate.

SOURCES AND METHOD

Where the research came from

Official legal and administrative documents are separated from advocacy and contextual sources. Links are clickable in a PDF viewer.

Method

I first extracted and visually checked the user-provided sample ballot, then compared its language against the final county ordinance, South Carolina statutes, SCDOR guidance, county budget and road materials, Travelers Rest ordinances and project exhibits, and official transit materials. I treated press reports and advocacy pages as context or stated positions, not as neutral proof. Where a public document changed over time, I kept the discrepancy visible rather than silently choosing the most favorable number.

Official ballot, law, and government sources

- User-provided sample ballot - Five-page sample ballot; local questions appear on page 5.
- [Greenville County final transportation-tax ordinance](#) - Final ordinance and county ballot language for Questions 1 and 2.
- [South Carolina Code, Section 4-37-30](#) - State transportation-facilities sales/use tax, bond, term, exemptions, and administration rules.
- [SCDOR local sales taxes](#) - Statewide and local sales-tax administration, including transportation taxes.
- [SCDOR sales-tax deductions](#) - Guidance on food, prescriptions, motor fuel, maximum-tax items, and local exemptions.
- [Greenville County 2024 road-needs presentation/minutes](#) - Staff-reported road, bridge, safety, and funding-gap figures.
- [Greenville County FY2026 budget](#) - Current-year road-program and county-finance context.
- [Greenville County road-maintenance fee code](#) - \$25-per-vehicle fee and permitted uses.
- [September 15, 2026 fee-repeal intent resolution](#) - Intent to repeal if the sales tax passes; not itself a completed repeal.
- [South Carolina Municipal Tax Relief Act, Act 866](#) - Travelers Rest tax authority, 20% credit allocation, exemptions, term, and administration.
- [Travelers Rest tax-relief page](#) - Current city explanation, ballot amounts, credit examples, timing, and tax base.
- [Travelers Rest project page and map](#) - Project descriptions, tiers, and interactive project information.
- [Travelers Rest July 2026 Council packet](#) - Ordinance and earlier Exhibit A project estimates.
- [Travelers Rest August 10, 2026 Council packet](#) - Later Exhibit A estimate used for the project tables in this guide.
- [Travelers Rest homeowner-tax-relief projection](#) - Eight-year collection and credit projection.
- [Greenlink FY2025 annual report](#) - Operating-expense context for the county transit allocation.

History, context, and stated advocacy

- [2024 Greenville County referendum results](#) - Reported 2024 county referendum result: 119,611 YES and 126,834 NO.
- [Greenville Chamber explainer](#) - Supportive business-advocacy explanation; used as a stated position, not independent verification.
- [Greenville Connects](#) - Transit-advocacy position that the transit share may be insufficient; used as advocacy context.
- [Greenville County GOP opposition page](#) - Opposition position emphasizing taxes, existing fee, and accountability; used as advocacy context.
- [Institute on Taxation and Economic Policy](#) - General research context on why sales taxes tend to be regressive.

Last reminder

This guide is a research summary, not legal, tax, engineering, or financial advice. Official ordinances, final bond documents, DOR guidance, budgets, bids, and later Council actions control implementation. If a point would change your vote, verify it against the linked primary source before Election Day.